

Chapter 152_3 - Punishing Heaven

"Divine Venerable, why don't you..." Tang Wenshu had just begun to speak when he was interrupted by Chu Qingqiu, who raised her hand to stop everyone. Her peach blossom eyes rarely showed fear.

She sensed an unknown powerful force, existing quietly under the dark eaves before them.

"Yiyi..." She couldn't help reaching for Ning Fuyi's hand, but before she could touch it, a figure leisurely walked out from under the vermillion eaves, gaunt-faced and standing with a smile.

The man's skin was ghastly pale from not seeing sunlight for so long. He pretentiously shielded himself from the light, his smooth voice raising goosebumps all around.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling, long time no see. I have been waiting for you..." He scratched his forehead, pretending to think, "Over two thousand years."

Chu Qingqiu's fingertips trembled slightly. She gripped the white bone tightly, and sensing its master's anger, the white bone emitted a low flute sound.

"So it really is you," Chu Qingqiu sneered lightly. "Truly long-lived—still lingering as a ghost after all this."

"No, no, no, I'm just an evil spirit born from malevolent thoughts. How could there be talk of being long-lived? If this body hadn't given me an opportunity to exploit, how would I have such vast and boundless magical power now?" The man said, spreading his arms wide.

Amid sounds of disgusted hissing, the skin on his face suddenly melted, forming a face with green eyebrows and red eyes. After laughing heartily for a few moments, it gradually changed back.

"This is clearly possession, not some opportunity to exploit," Ning Fuyi frowned.

The man's gaze turned to Ning Fuyi, examining her like a perfect treasure. Ning Fuyi was made uncomfortable by his stare, gripping the Emei Thorn until it was rigid.

"Don't be hasty. Haven't you always wanted to become a demon? I am the strongest demon in the world. You and I are naturally kindred spirits," the man chuckled.

"Ptui," Ning Fuyi spat at the ground.

"Besides, how is this possession? If this body hadn't harbored desires to unify the six realms, how could I have easily occupied his body?" The man slowly walked down the steps, his robes and hem dragging on the ground.

"Now I'm helping him unify the world. I'm about to succeed," the man said with a smile.

The man said no more. The moment his toes touched the final step, the roof of the great hall behind him suddenly shattered, and golden light more dazzling than sunlight forced everyone to raise their hands and close their eyes.

Chu Qingqiu silently cursed—the powerful force she had sensed poured out from within the hall like a dragon trapped in an abyss.

When everyone opened their eyes again, the sky that had been covered with dark clouds was blocked by a thin curtain. This curtain spanned a radius of dozens of li, blocking sun, moon, and stars. The crisscrossing lines on it flickered with flowing light, sweeping across the earth like wheels, shocking and terrifying everyone present.

"What... what is this thing..." Li Hanhan had already lost color in her face. She grabbed Tang Wenshu beside her. "The power it contains is so terrifying!"

Ning Fuyi also felt a wave of heart palpitations. The curtain and the mountains and rivers embroidered on it writhed with flowing light, causing terror that made one's scalp tingle.

Some elders with weaker immortal power had already gone weak in the knees, staggering and kneeling.

Emperor Tianrui looked up at the sky with delight, his eyes full of excitement. While admiring his masterpiece, he raised his hand and sent out a gust of wind. Where the wind touched, everything immediately turned black.

At the same time, he laughed loudly and threw out a scroll. What appeared in the scroll was precisely the scene of the six realms. Where the wind had just fallen was the Eastern Wasteland, so monstrous waves covered the sky and earth in the scroll, instantly reducing coastal fishing ports to rubble.

The wails of mortals came through the scroll. Everyone present glared with fury, while Emperor Tianrui's eyes flashed with mad and fierce light as he said softly: "And what he promised me is about to be realized. The first step is—the destruction of the human race."

Having said this, before anyone could react, his harsh laughter had already echoed before the hall. Even standing in mid-air, one could feel the trembling of the mountains and rivers below.

The Mountain and River Map overhead flickered faster and faster, preparing to tear itself apart amid endless vibrations.

"No good, this thing is about to tear!" Everyone looked up and shouted. At the same time, a white figure leaped into mid-air, giant layered gardenia petals blooming beneath her feet.

Those petals bloomed with the formation, then transformed into countless wispy white smoke, firmly enveloping the Mountain and River Map. The white smoke actually overshadowed the curtain for a moment, and the trembling beneath their feet gradually subsided.

That figure was like a heavenly god, firmly restraining the power that could destroy mountains and rivers.

"Divine Venerable! Quickly go help the Divine Venerable!" The others shouted and stepped forward. Dozens of brilliant immortal powers surged into the sky, forming colorful ribbons that filled the sky with a long rainbow.

Ning Fuyi initially looked up, then noticed the gardenia fragrance at her nose tip was overly strong, finally realizing that Chu Qingqiu was forcing herself. She was about to step forward when two figures blocked her path, forcing her to circulate her power to resist in urgency.

Yun Ke and Wen Yao Jun both entangled her. Wen Yao Jun's magical power was still weak, but Yun Ke was a merman—how could he be ordinary? After several exchanges, she actually broke out in a cold sweat on her back.

But this cold sweat wasn't from the enemies before her, but from the sudden sharp pain in her head. For some reason, her sea of consciousness was like a great fire had ignited, the burning irritation making her dizzy and confused.

In a moment of dizziness, the silver ring in Wen Yao Jun's hand struck her heart directly. Ning Fuyi felt a fishy sweetness surge in her throat, and Yun Ke's coral sword was already stabbing toward her forehead.

The moment her forehead was pierced and bleeding, a figure like raging fire pulled her behind him, taking on the entanglement of the two.

"Ning Fuyi, how did you become so useless?" Jiuying appeared from somewhere unknown, her robes becoming afterimages as she slapped Wen Yao Jun to the ground with one palm, then turned to face Yun Ke.

Ning Fuyi had wanted to retort, but her legs went weak and she knelt down. She didn't know where she had bitten herself, but she tasted blood and looked up angrily.

Jiuying also noticed something was wrong and reached back to help Ning Fuyi, but Yun Ke had already surged forward with waves, forcing her to be pushed away.

"Ning Fuyi! What's wrong with you!" Jiuying's urgent voice mixed with the clash of weapons, seeming to come from beyond the heavens.

"Why aren't you moving?" Emperor Tianrui said gently, his voice particularly clear. "You're very angry. You and I share the same source—I can sense your anger."

"It was you who planted the demonic root. How could I associate with a maggot like you!" Ning Fuyi forcibly suppressed the churning in her stomach, speaking quietly.

"I chose you, so you are me," Emperor Tianrui laughed lightly. He suddenly snapped his fingers, and the stabbing pain in Ning Fuyi's head became even worse, striking her down to the ground.

Emperor Tianrui looked up at the Mountain and River Map, spreading his hands with satisfaction: "This lord has endured hardships for over two thousand years. If I didn't have complete confidence, how would I act rashly?"

"This lord has two magical artifacts. One is the world-destroying Mountain and River Map."

"The other is you," he giggled.

Having lived two lifetimes, Ning Fuyi had never felt such terror. His laughter crawled over her scalp like flies, making her tremble uncontrollably.

She was about to retreat when another figure suddenly fell before her eyes, robes fresh green like spring grass in the mountains, a clear voice tinged with tears: "Father Emperor, don't!"

Father Emperor? Ning Fuyi's vision alternated between black and white. She struggled to raise her right hand, grasping something hanging at her chest. Only when her palm was pierced by that object did her vision barely clear.

That figure was small and delicate, with jingling ornaments at her waist as always. She was almost kneeling in front of Ning Fuyi, pleading with the man before them.

Emperor Tianrui's expression changed upon seeing this, even his eyes showing some variation: "Shiqi! Get away from there quickly!"

"Father Emperor! Please don't listen to that demon anymore. It will destroy the six realms and ruin all of Penglai!" Baili Shiqi spread her slender arms in front of Ning Fuyi. "Father Emperor..."

"Get away!" Emperor Tianrui's eyes also showed terror. He tried to wave his hand to take the woman away, but ice-blue immortal power blocked all his force.

"Shiqi, leave quickly," Ning Fuyi was trembling all over from pain. She desperately raised her hand trying to pull Baili Shiqi away, but the delicate body was like a thousand-pound anchor, not moving an inch.

Then she heard the tiny sound of something piercing flesh. The arm in her palm suddenly became draggable, even falling to one side on its own.

Ning Fuyi watched helplessly as Baili Shiqi fell backward toward her, the thin body that could be encircled with one arm slipping into her embrace, head tilting back to rest on her shoulder.

The wind around them seemed to stop. The man's voice was howling in pain, but the howling gradually weakened. Accompanied by the change in his eyes, the howling became mocking laughter.

Emperor Tianrui rotated his head to relax the reclaimed body, shaking his shoulders pleasantly, and indifferently spat out two words: "Fool."

Ning Fuyi kept her eyes open. They first blurred, then something scalding fell from her eye sockets, but her body couldn't move even half an inch. She could only feel the hot blood flowing from the body in her arms, soaking through her clothes.

"Sister Ning..." Baili Shiqi's voice, always containing laughter, sounded somewhat weak.

"Sister Ning, the purest blood of the Penglai clan can restore the memories of those whose memories have been reshaped..." Baili Shiqi said. "There's one more thing."

She struggled to get close to Ning Fuyi's ear.

"Remember, truth and falsehood, what the eyes see is illusion."

"Remember, Ning..."

Before she could finish saying "sister," the hand that had been gripping Ning Fuyi lost its strength and slid softly to the ground. Her eyes, clean as a clear lake, slowly dimmed.

"No, Shiqi... Shiqi..." Ning Fuyi tried to feel for her pulse, but everywhere she touched was soft silence.

That Shiqi who had crisply called her Sister Ning when they first met, that Shiqi who had pulled her out of the dungeon when she was in despair, that Shiqi who always carried pure laughter.

Ning Fuyi wanted to scream, but her throat seemed voiceless. Indescribable anger swelled within her, but no matter what, she couldn't find an outlet.

The Mountain and River Map overhead was about to shatter. Some edges already had cracks, accompanied by terrified shouts from unknown sources. She seemed to have her soul extracted, standing on broken land.

Ning Fuyi drifted like a panoramic view through that once extremely familiar territory. Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate had completely collapsed, broken mountain stones tumbling down, burying Dianxing Town at the foot of the mountain.

The Marriage Bridge broke in the middle, dozens of people fell into the river water. Amid struggles and cries for help, they were crushed into bloody pulp by boulders from the mountain peak.

Children ran crying, also struck by falling rocks, their small bodies splattering with blood.

Ning Fuyi's eyes were filled with desolation. She wanted to help, but her hands couldn't be raised no matter what. She had never hated her powerlessness so much. Then the scene flashed, and she stood in another area where yellow sand had buried villages, leaving only scattered chimneys exposed.

A small hand reached out from beneath her feet. She tremblingly pulled the hand out, and a gray-blue face appeared before her eyes.

Ying Ge'er¹.

Ning Fuyi suddenly screamed in agony, curling up on the ground, her voice extremely mournful.

"Ning Fuyi!" Jiuying called her sternly, urgently summoning killing intent. She suddenly transformed into a beast, her fangs piercing the exhausted Wen Yao Jun completely through. He died without a sound.

She was about to rush directly to Ning Fuyi's side when Emperor Tianrui's eyes flashed coldly. He raised his hand and struck down with a palm. Jiuying tried to resist, but how could she match Tianrui's divine power? She was immediately sent flying, crashing into ruins.

In the spinning world, Ning Fuyi returned to consciousness drenched in cold sweat, the lingering pain not yet gone. She lay on the ground, first seeing Shiqi's cold body, then seeing the smiling Emperor Tianrui.

Emperor Tianrui was still smiling, as if enjoying a good show. He looked at Ning Fuyi with satisfaction, satisfied to see black mist gradually emerging around her, the black mist drilling into her heart and lungs, then overflowing from her eyes.

The man rotated his wrists, suddenly producing clusters of black smoke in his palms.

"Ning Fuyi!" Chu Qingqiu in the sky spat out blood, the fresh blood flowing down from the corners of her mouth, dripping all over her body.

At this moment, all her strength was controlling the Mountain and River Map, and her heart and lungs had long been severely injured.

"Divine Venerable! You cannot leave. Our power is insufficient to suppress this thing. If you withdraw, the mortal realm will be completely destroyed!" The Gujian Sect leader saw her losing strength and shouted in pain.

"Yes, Divine Venerable, you absolutely cannot let go!" Others also pleaded desperately.

Chu Qingqiu stared at the Mountain and River Map overhead, tears falling amid the pleas. The moment tears mixed with bloodstains, a few traces of madness appeared in her cold eyes.

"Yiyi..." she murmured.

The moment black smoke surged toward Ning Fuyi, white robes fell in time. Wind mixed with ice crystals flew up, resisting and dispersing the black smoke. The power that spread regardless of everything pushed even Emperor Tianrui back several steps in surprise, looking up in shock.

Ning Fuyi also couldn't believe it. She had been certain that Chu Qingqiu would choose all living beings, and she had always gone along with that choice.

But now, that figure was finally protecting only her alone.

Chu Qingqiu's blood flowed more and more, gushing from her mouth and staining her white robes red. She stood palm to palm with Emperor Tianrui, even with her meridians completely ruptured, she didn't move an inch.

Ning Fuyi suddenly smiled. She rolled over and lay down. The Mountain and River Map in the sky was stabilized again by a black shadow that had rushed from somewhere, golden light blazing so brightly it was searing, burning tears that fell drop by drop.

At this moment, she suddenly understood the meaning of that Sanskrit phrase in the Divine-Demon Art.

Demons are inherently sinless. What devoured her consciousness was demonic qi, but what allowed it to occupy her heart's gate was actually herself.

"When good acts as good, it ceases to be good."

"The source of gods and demons both lie in a single thought."

She suddenly turned over, half-kneeling to support herself. While shattering the seal within her body, she raised her right hand and touched the small pendant that had hung around her neck for thirty years.

"Longing," she declared loudly.

Chu Qingqiu was about to exhaust her strength when suddenly thick black mist arose all around. Chu Qingqiu's immortal power was severed from within, and she staggered backward, but was gently supported by the rampaging black mist.

Looking up in confusion, one black and one pink lightning bolt tore through the sky. A tall figure appeared before everyone's eyes, the left side of her body wrapped in rolling black qi, while the right side flickered with brilliant pink light.

At the same time, the demons outside the hall all stopped fighting and turned to watch the sky suddenly filled with demonic clouds, saying in amazement: "This is..."

The Heaven-Punishing God-Demon!

Footnotes:

1. **Ying Ge'er (鸢鹄儿)** - The name of a young child, likely from the mortal realm, whom Ning Fuyi had encountered earlier in the story